his statement at the AGM, Ratan also revealed his continued focus on overseas expansion.

As a part of the strategy to tap into the overseas capital markets, in September 2004, Tata Motors made its debut on the New York Stock Exchange. It became the ‘first Indian engineering’ and the second company from the Tata Group to enlist abroad.

The following year, Tata Motors rolled out two luxury variants of Indigo, unveiled the new Indica V2 Turbo and India’s first sports utility truck, Tata TL 4x4. It also launched a ‘wide range of fully built buses and coaches called “Globus” and “Starbus”’.

One of the primary goals of Ratan’s restructuring programme was for Tata Motors to develop consumer focus, to shed the company of its traditional outlook of producing for a sellers’ market. And this found remarkable expression in a new vehicle called Tata Ace.

Ace was ‘conceived as a product “from the customer, for the customer”’. It targeted the truck and three-wheeler operators in both urban and rural India. The ‘idea of a “cheap … and rugged vehicle for India”’ was aimed at filling the gap in Tata Motors’ product portfolio to serve the ‘last-mile’ distribution. It began as a small operation, in light of the severe cost-cutting measures implemented after 2001. The team was led by Wagh, at the time a thirty-year-old engineer. It only had five people working on a full-time basis and had a development budget that was only a tad more than one quarter of the Indica’s. The Ace was developed in-house by the completely revamped Engineering Research Centre (ERC), Pune.

When it was launched in 2005, the mini truck became an instant success. It fell into an entirely new product category, occupying a niche area in the Indian transportation sector at a price comparable with that of a three-wheeler. The company’s annual target of 30,000 vehicles was achieved in less than a year, despite it being available in only approximately 25 per cent of the country. In the end, the Ace outclassed perhaps any other product developed and undertaken by Tata Motors in terms of outcome exceeding expectation.

Prakash Telang, then executive director of commercial vehicles, says, ‘[The] Ace taught us to listen to the customer, deliver the product to the customer and continue listening to the customer.’ M.V. Rajarao, then vice president (manufacturing), says that the Ace was a classic example of a vehicle that was ‘designed totally based on customer feedback’. It became a